ONE-OFF SHIURIM

Forces, Angels and Souls: Inside the Spiritual World

Derech Hashem, Maamar Halkarim

Sefer: Maamar Halkarim by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal), printed at the end of Derech Hashem **Section:** Maamar Halkarim, essay 2: the spiritual realm (first part) **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Derech Hashem series at Tiferet Eyal, Monday 23 May 2022

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Recap and introduction

The first essay was mostly about what God is not: He cannot be divided, duplicated or given a body, and we must be careful not to attribute to Him things that are incorrect. The second essay, on the spiritual realm, is largely a summary of the last two chapters of Part 1 of Derech Hashem. The Rabbi said it "flows very nicely".

Spiritual creatures have laws too

God created physical bodies that we can all see, people, animals and every other creature, and He also created higher creatures that our senses cannot detect. Just as He gave physical creatures boundaries and laws of nature (our bodies cannot fly), He gave the spiritual creatures their own laws, as His wisdom decided.

The Rabbi called this a common mistake: people think something spiritual can do anything, that an angel can do anything. "Absolutely not." Spiritual beings have set roles, goals and boundaries within which they operate. We call something physical if we can touch, see or smell it, and spiritual if we cannot, but both are governed by laws. And just as each physical species has its own laws, so does each spiritual species.

A participant mentioned mystics said to levitate while meditating. The Rabbi was sceptical ("Show me evidence. Show me a video"), and the discussion came back to the point: whatever spiritual beings can do, they act within limits. He also said frankly that we do not know their laws in detail. "What I can tell you is that they exist, and they have their laws which govern them."

Reading the texts carefully

The group asked about angels taking physical form, such as the three angels who visited Avraham. The Rabbi noted that the Rambam holds this happened in a prophetic vision, since in his view an angel cannot take physical form. Others read it more literally. Either way, he urged care: the Torah also says God has eyes and fingers, and when it says God "came down"

to see Sodom, we are forced to read it differently from the plain words. Perhaps angels sometimes appear physically, perhaps it is a metaphor; what matters is how we read the text.

The three main species

The Ramhal divides the spiritual world into three main categories. Within each, as with animals and mammals, there are many kinds.

1. **Kohot (forces).** Spiritual entities without any body, very fine and very elevated, the highest form of spiritual being and the closest to the Divine. As learned in Part 1, every physical thing has a parallel force above it. When God creates a table, He creates its koah. The Ofanim, the "wheels" of Yehezkel's vision, are a type of koah.
2. **Malakhim (messengers).** Created to carry out God's will. The Rabbi insisted on the translation. "A malakh is not an angel. A malakh is a messenger." We should drop the picture of figures in white cloaks with their own personalities. He compared a malakh to a self-driving car sent on an errand: it does what it has been programmed to do. Each is appointed to a specific task, at a specific level, with laws according to its level.
3. **Neshamot (souls).** Spiritual entities destined to enter bodies and be bound up with them. Their laws change with their circumstances: before entering the body, while in the body, and after leaving it.

Can a messenger overstep its mission?

A participant asked: if a malakh is only a messenger, how could the angels in Sodom decide to strike the people with blindness, or how do the Midrashim describe angels doing things that seem to go beyond their task? The Rabbi called it a fantastic and major question. The answer that emerged was that this too is their programming. A car's maker might deliberately programme a test crash; it looks like a malfunction, but it is the design. The Ramhal himself discusses this in a later essay, explaining that what looks like an angel's sin is really part of its mission and comes to teach us something.

Good and destructive messengers

All the malakhim carry out God's word, and everything that happens in the world comes through them, for good and for bad. That is why there are two groups. One brings good, physical or spiritual. The other are the malakhei habalah, destructive messengers. The Rabbi warned against importing the Christian idea of a Satan acting against God. "They're doing God's will, but they're doing God's will to do something which we perceive as bad."

He connected the three categories to the four worlds of Kabbalah: Asilut is God, Beriah is where the forces are created, Yesirah is the malakhim bringing them out and implementing them, and Asiyah is the physical world of the neshamah. A participant objected that surely the human soul is the highest, as the Gemara says souls are kept beneath the Throne of Glory. The Rabbi accepted that the forces are above the messengers, who need them in order to act, and suggested the order refers to the soul in the body, which has come down in level. He added that hibbut hakever, the suffering of the grave, belongs to the body, not the soul.

The next class would discuss demons, a hybrid between the physical and spiritual worlds.

Summary

- Just as physical creatures have laws of nature, spiritual creatures have fixed laws and limits; nothing spiritual can do whatever it wants.
- The spiritual world has three main species: kohot (forces), malakhim (messengers) and neshamot (souls).
- A malakh is a messenger carrying out a mission, not a free-willed winged figure.
- Even destructive messengers do God's will; there is no power working against Him.
- Texts describing God or angels in physical terms must be read carefully.

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